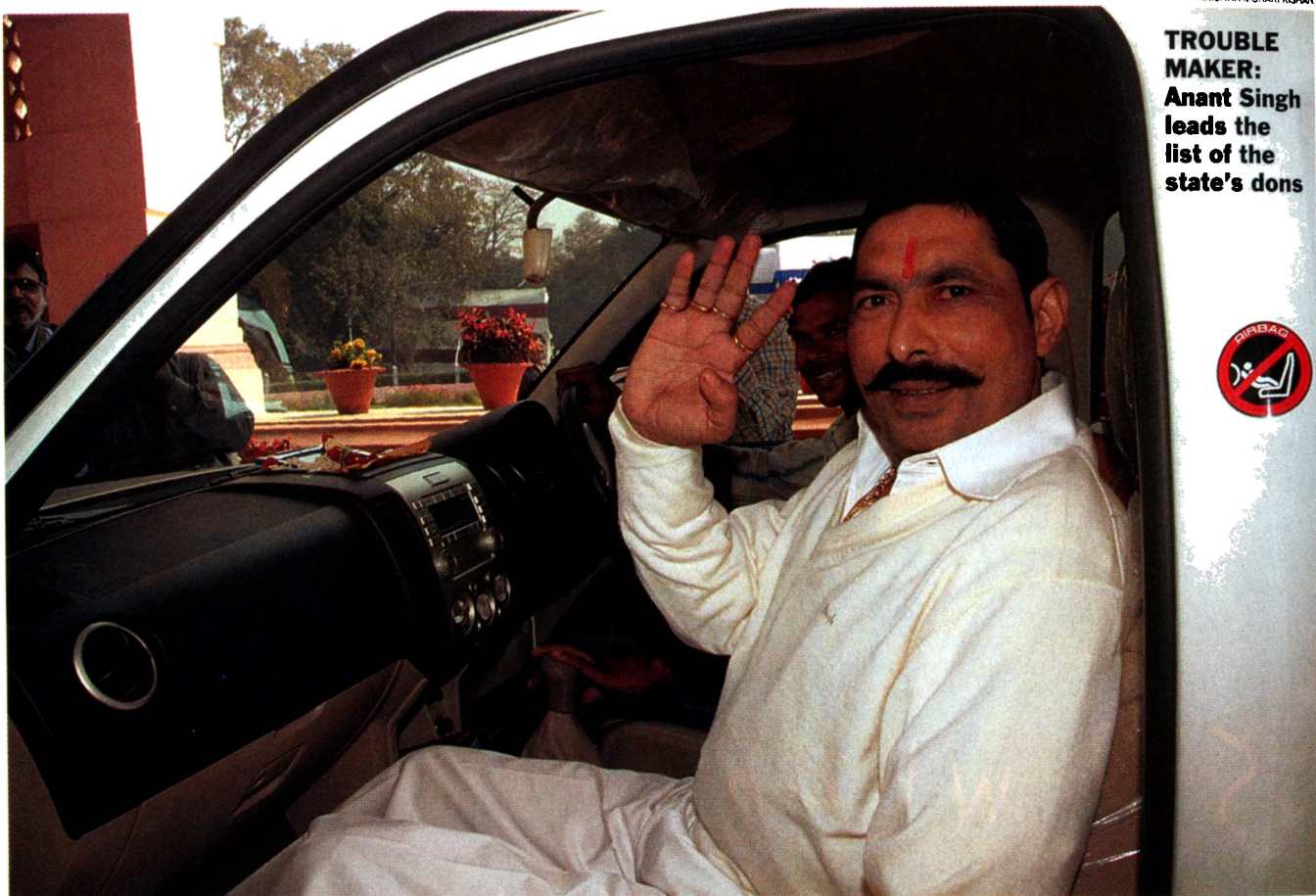




TROUBLE MAKER:
Anant Singh leads the list of the state's dons



POWERED BY CRIME

Despite the courts handing harsh sentences to more than half-a-dozen dreaded politicians in the past, the state is witnessing the emergence of a brash new breed of political dons

■ By Amitabh Srivastava

The more things change, the more they remain the same. And nowhere in this country is this cliché more apt than in Bihar, where a new breed of strongman-politicians, a.k.a dons, has emerged. What is even more surprising is the fact that these don-turned-politicians have refused to learn a lesson from a spate of judgements that various courts in Bihar have pronounced against their seniors Pappu Yadav and Shahabuddin in the past.

Seven of the notorious bad boys of Bihar politics have been awarded life imprisonment for plotting murders and abductions, while three others have been sentenced to death. But these strictures have had no impact on the second generation political

toughies, several of whom have had a number of cases registered against them in recent times. They include JD(U) MLAs Neeraj Kumar Singh "Bablu", Anant Singh, Jai Kumar Singh and Sunil Pandey, who has now been suspended from the party. The list also includes BJP MLA Prem Ranjan Patel, and RJD MP Sitaram Yadav.

What is worrying is that a number of these strongman-politicians belong to the party of Chief Minister Nitish Kumar, who has made *sushasan* (good governance) his mantra. And it is JD(U) legislator Anant Singh who leads the pack. The Patna Police have so far refrained from taking any

action against him, although he has recently been accused of masterminding the murder of Sanjay Kumar Singh, a part time contractor. Sanjay was gunned down on January 8 on the bustling Boring Canal Road in Patna. Although the victim's brother has named Anant as the main conspirator behind the killing in the FIR, the police are still "ascertaining the veracity of the allegations."

Meanwhile, Anant's followers have approached the police, claiming that the MLA is innocent and was in New Delhi for medical treatment when the murder took place. Deputy Chief Minister Sushil Kumar Modi has also

"The NDA Government does not offer protection to anyone involved in criminal cases."

SUSHIL KUMAR MODI, DEPUTY CHIEF MINISTER